

MAN OF MANY WORLDS
Works by Lalit Mohan Sen on display at the exhibition

As the paintings of mountains and of Garhwali village folk show, academic realism was Sen's forte and he excelled in portraiture and landscape painting. His mastery of draughtsmanship is apparent from his delicate graphite and conti figure studies.

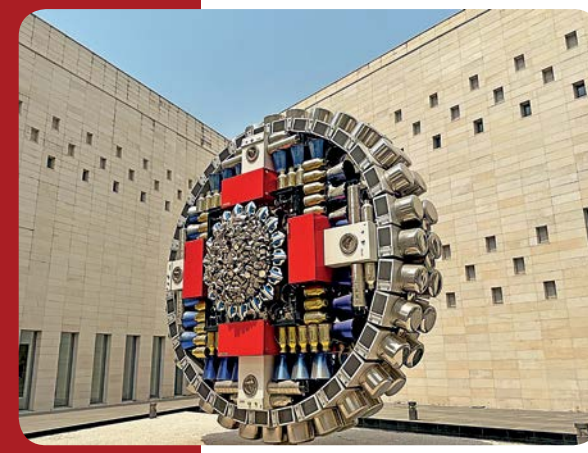
Sen kept an open mind and drew inspiration on the one hand from classical Indian art and the country's rich tradition of crafts, and on the other, from Abanindranath Tagore's Bengal School of Art and the *swadeshi* values that it was based on. Sen's painting of the woman disrobing herself for the emperor's eyes only is a case in point. For him, no dichotomy existed between the Western and Indian legacies and he helped himself liberally to both. Little wonder then that Robert Laurence Binyon, the English litterateur and art scholar, commissioned Sen to copy the Bagh Cave paintings.

Sen may not have actively participated in the Indian freedom movement, but he was deeply sympathetic towards it. His portraits of Mahatma Gandhi are strong testimonies. Sen demonstrated his mastery of the Indian style of painting when in 1930 he was among the four Indian artists hired to decorate the newly built India House in London. He painted the two large-scale murals based on Buddha's life and of Akbar.

Widely travelled, Sen's sketchbook and camera were his constant companions and photography was his métier. His art may seem dated today but his photographs, lit by a soft, pellucid glow, have not lost their appeal. ■

Soumitra Das

IN STEP WITH THE TIMES
An installation at the Bihar Museum



ART

United in Art

The **Bihar Museum Biennale** is back for an ambitious second edition

The Bihar Museum Biennale is set to begin its second edition on August 7, which also happens to be the Museum's Foundation Day. This will be the first in-person edition after the pandemic forced a wholly virtual first edition in 2021. Organised by the Department of Arts, Culture and Youth Affairs, Government of Bihar, the four-month-long Biennale will see museums from across the country and overseas displaying exhibits that span over 10,000 years of recorded history. Works by artists and photographers from around the world will also be on display—all G20 nations and nine guest nations, alongside well-known Indian names like Raghu Rai, Arpana Caur, Bose Krishnamachari, K.S. Radhakrishnan et al have contributed works around the theme of 'Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam' (One World, One Family), as part of the exhibition *Together We Art*, which will be on till the end of October.

Art historian Dr Alka Pande, the chief curator of the Biennale, says, "There are numerous ways in which one can make an exhibition space more interactive. One is technology, of course, but we are also looking at how people engage with objects, at how they react to themes like climate change, and so on. We have an exhibit coming in from the Natural History Museum (UK) which is basically a five-metre-tall robotic plant, that uses biodiversity prediction data sourced from the museum."

A full spread of conversations about curatorial practices and the future of museums has been planned in two separate batches, from August 8-9 and August 22-23. Participating professionals include Lars-Christian Koch, director, Staatliche Museen zu Berlin, Yannick Lintz, president, Musee Guimet (Paris), Pheroza Godrej, founder-director, Cymroza Art Gallery (Mumbai), Rakhi Sarkar, founder, CIMA (Centre of International Modern Art, Kolkata), et al. Among other things, the discussion will map how museum culture in India can keep pace with the rest of the world and implement best curatorial practices across the country. A pair of photography exhibitions functioned as the curtain-raiser for the Biennale, among them *Nature Strikes Back* consisting of photographs by Emmanuel Lenain, ambassador of France to India.

Dr Pande says, "Over the last 10-20 years especially, man has taken nature for granted, and in these photographs, we see how certain spaces abandoned by us have been 'reclaimed' by nature. I think when people see these images, they'll be forced to think about our rapidly changing equation with our surroundings." She adds, "I'd like to point out the key role played by Anjani Kumar Singh, the nodal officer of the Bihar Museum and advisor to Chief Minister Nitish Kumar.... Every man and woman in Bihar has a strong sense of cultural pride and, hopefully, the Biennale will add to that and showcase it to the rest of the world." ■

Aditya Mani Jha